ISI refused to let him be interviewed alone by US intelligence officers (presumably because he would have revealed too much about their working relationship). [21]

Pakistani military and intelligence leaders have employed a range of responses to charges of supporting terrorism. One has been to flatly deny any links, as they did after the 2008 Indian Embassy bombing in Kabul and the 26/11 attacks in Mumbai. Terrorism against targets in Afghanistan were sometimes justified by the notion of ‘strategic depth’, a somewhat preposterous idea that Pakistani forces can fall back into Afghanistan in the event of an Indian invasion from the east. Pakistani military and civilian leaders also complained about Indian encirclement and long exaggerated India’s security presence in Afghanistan (for example, the media arm of Pakistan’s military propagated the notion that India was running intelligence operations out of dozens of consulates in Afghanistan, when in fact India never had more than four). All of this has served to justify Pakistan’s support for terrorist groups.

India has attempted to address this compound challenge from Pakistan through both negative and positive leverage: ‘sticks’ and ‘carrots’. The sticks have included a military mobilization in 2001–02 after the attack on the Indian Parliament, known as Operation Parakram. More recently, in response to major terrorist attacks at Uri and Pulwama, India responded with ground based ‘surgical strikes’ across the Line of Control and air strikes on Balakot. The intention of these actions was to reduce predictability in India’s responses. While continuing efforts will have to be made to increase India’s punitive options against Pakistan—such as diplomatic efforts to isolate and condemn Pakistan and link economic assistance and benefits to its support for terrorism, such as through the Financial Action Task Force—it will be necessary to continuously develop military contingency plans.

Meanwhile, ‘carrots’ have consistently been rejected by Pakistan, such as Indian efforts to normalize trade relations and conclude a transit trade agreement with Afghanistan. Even efforts at improving diplomatic relations —from the Lahore summit of 1999 to President Asif Ali Zardari’s outreach